

The Sock Goblin

storycraft sample

The Sock Goblin

Chapter 1 — The Accusation

Mar had two striped socks on Monday morning.

She had zero striped socks by Tuesday.

“This,” she told her notebook, “is a crime.”

She had been keeping track. Seven socks gone in three weeks. Always just one from a pair. Never a plain white one. The sock thief had *taste*, which made it worse.

Mar uncapped her best pen and wrote: *Stakeout tonight. Laundry room. Bring flashlight.*

The laundry room smelled like warm fabric and dryer sheets. Mar crouched behind the laundry basket with her flashlight off and her notebook ready. The dryer rumbled and shuddered. The vent huffed a little puff of lint into the air, soft as a breath. Mar waited.

Nothing happened for a long time.

She ate a cracker. She wrote *nothing yet* in her notebook. She waited some more.

Then she heard it — a small, skittery sound. Like a mouse, but tidier.

Mar clicked on her flashlight.

A creature no bigger than a cereal box stood beside the dryer. It had round amber eyes, ears like folded paper, and very small hands. It was holding Mar’s striped sock.

Mar’s mouth dropped open.

The creature’s eyes went wide. It clutched the sock to its chest like a baby bird.

“THIEF!” Mar yelled.

The creature let out a squeak and bolted — but Mar was faster. She grabbed the big metal colander from the dish rack and slammed it down over the creature like a dome.

The creature froze. Through the holes in the colander, two amber eyes stared up at her.

“Ha,” said Mar. She sat on her heels and pointed her flashlight at the prisoner. “Got you. You’re the sock goblin.”

The creature straightened up very carefully. It smoothed its tiny jacket, which was stitched together from dryer-sheet squares. It cleared its throat.

“My name,” it said, in a small but dignified voice, “is Pib.”

“Okay, Pib.” Mar flipped open her notebook. “Why did you steal my sock?”

Pib’s ears went flat against his head. He looked at the sock in his hands, then at Mar. He took a breath so big that his whole chest puffed out.

“Technically,” he said, “I was *saving* it.”

Mar’s pen stopped moving. She looked at the goblin. The striped sock was — now that she noticed — perfectly clean, neatly folded, and tucked against Pib’s chest like something precious.

She looked back at Pib.

“Saving it,” she repeated, “from *what*?”

Pib pressed his lips together. His amber eyes flickered toward a dark gap behind the dryer.

“That,” he said quietly, “is a very long story.”

Chapter 2 — The Lint Tide

Mar lifted the colander one inch.

“Start talking,” she said.

Pib straightened his dryer-sheet jacket and held the striped sock a little tighter. “If you lift that all the way,” he said, “I’ll show you faster than I can explain it.”

Mar thought about this. Pib’s amber eyes were steady. They did not look like liar eyes. She had written descriptions of liar eyes in her notebook.

She lifted the colander all the way.

Pib didn’t run. He turned toward the dark gap behind the dryer and waved for her to follow.

Mar followed.

The gap was barely wide enough for her hand. Behind the dryer drum, the heat had dried the dust into something strange — a slow, soft current of warm air that smelled like lavender and old cotton. Bits of lint drifted through it like snow falling sideways.

“The Lint Tide,” Pib said. He kept his voice low, the way you do near something powerful. “It blows every time the dryer runs. It goes under the drum, through the gap, and into my burrow.” He pointed to a small round hole in the baseboard, neatly edged with a ring of buttons. “But here — right here — is the real trouble.”

He aimed his finger at a spot near the bottom of the drum gap. A dark crescent-shaped hole, barely wider than two fingers.

“Socks catch on the lip of the drum,” Pib said. “One at a time. Always the odd one — the one nearest the gap. The Lint Tide pulls it in, and then they fall through *that*.” He pointed to the crescent. “Without me, they’re gone. Lost in the walls. Forever.”

Mar crouched and peered at the crescent hole. She could see a sock in there right now — white with blue stripes, wedged in the dark.

Her sock.

She sat back on her heels and looked at Pib. “You’ve been fishing them out,” she said.

“Rescuing,” Pib said firmly. “The word is rescuing.”

“With what?”

“I had a very good hook made from a paperclip and some thread.” He patted his jacket pocket sadly. “I dropped it on Tuesday. That’s why I hadn’t gotten yours back yet.”

Mar opened her notebook. She chewed her pen cap. Then she tore out a page.

“I have string,” she said. “Do you have anything we could use for a net?”

Pib’s whole face changed — ears lifting, eyes going bright. He disappeared into his burrow and came back with a piece of mesh from an old laundry bag, smaller than a playing card, with the edges sewn tight.

“I’ve been planning this for a while,” he said.

“I can tell,” said Mar.

They worked together on the laundry room floor. Mar cut the string in lengths and Pib tied the knots — his small hands were faster than hers. He made knots Mar had never seen before, knots that looked like tiny flowers. In seven minutes they had a net attached to a loop of string.

Mar lowered it into the crescent hole. She could feel the Lint Tide breathing warm air across her wrist.

She swept the net sideways.

Something thumped against the mesh.

She drew it up slowly.

The striped sock came with it, dusty but whole.

“Oh,” said Mar softly.

Pib let out a long, quiet breath and pressed one small hand to his chest.

Mar shook the sock out and held it up. Both stripes were still there. She folded it neatly enough and set it on top of the dryer.

Then she opened her notebook to the page that said *SOCK GOBLIN — SUSPECT*.

She drew one line through the word *SUSPECT*.

She wrote two words underneath.

Ally. (Pib.)

She showed it to him.

Pib's ears rose slowly, like a question turning into an answer.

"Technically," he said, "this is the best notebook I have ever been written into."

Mar capped her pen. "It's the only notebook you've ever been written into."

"Yes," said Pib. "That's what makes it the best."

Mar put the notebook in her pocket. The Lint Tide breathed softly through the gap. On top of the dryer, the striped sock waited to be reunited with its pair.